

Reflections on Grading the Exams

HI 254-601, Fall 2024

The Essay (50 points on exam, but graded on 100 point scale)

I (Professor Mitchell) corrected all the essays. They were good! It was a challenging question and most of you wrote essays that showed thought and a basic grasp of US history since Reconstruction. Well done!

The most common problem was the lack of a clear thesis. Many of you diligently – and often skillfully – recapped US history, but the prompt asked you to ANALYZE the past, not to simply recount it.

The essays with no clear thesis could be impressive in their grasp of history but they did not address the fundamental question: WHY did the expansion of US power abroad and civil rights at home occur during the same time span?

Ideally you should have decided how to explain the rise of both trends – civil rights & superpowerdom – and then written about where they overlapped and where they were in opposition. **Many of you focused on the rise of civil rights and barely explained how the United States became a superpower.**

There was no “right” answer. There are many, many possible theses.

For example, **you could have written about how the following factors impacted both US global power and civil rights (positively and negatively):**

- the development of the US **economy** from 1890-2010 led to both overseas expansion and the rise of groups at home demanding their share of the wealth;
- the **wars** (Spanish American, WW1, WW2, Korea, Vietnam, Terror) expanded both US power and civil rights – but note, too, that civil liberties have been severely limited in wartime (e.g., Espionage & Sedition Acts in WW1; internment of Japanese in WW2; Patriot Act in War on Terror)
- the **US military** – extending power abroad and in some ways at the forefront of social change (integration in 1948; women in more prominent roles, including combat in 2013.)
- While it is true that the absence of equal rights at home showed **the hypocrisy** of Americans asserting that they stood for freedom and equality this only became

crucial during the Cold War, when the United States was battling the Soviet Union for “hearts & minds.”

- changing **technologies** affected both civil rights and expansion
- changing **cultural trends and mores**
- **domestic politics**
- the need for a government to have **legitimacy** in order to wield power abroad; that legitimacy must come from the majority of the people;
- One of you focused on the role that **fear** played both in the growth of US global dominance and in the struggles for civil rights. I hadn’t thought of this thesis – and I liked it!
- Both the road to superpowerdom and the expansion of civil rights have been **very rocky processes**, with many setbacks; both have generated powerful backlashes.
- You could also argue that there is a negative relationship between the rise to superpowerdom & the expansion of civil rights, that **US foreign escapades have only hampered oppressed groups at home**. Oppressed and marginalized people have had to fight tooth and nail to get any justice from the elites who always focus on amassing power overseas.

I hope you can see that developing a thesis is not the same as simply summarizing chronologically the period of US history we have studied. You needed to analyze WHY both trends happened.

On a more mundane note, some of you lost points because you did not do what I specified in the prompt. Common omissions were:

- point out both when fight for civil rights at home and power abroad **diverged**.
- a **title** indicating your thesis
- **consider the entire century-plus**
- **base your analysis on facts.**
- a good **introduction** and **conclusion**.
- Proper **footnoting**

On a contemporary note, it was interesting to read your essays in a moment when the Supreme Court has revoked the constitutional right to abortion and, eventually – possibly – more. There is always a backlash to the expansion of civil rights, but for the Supreme Court to take away a right is extraordinary. It is impossible not to worry that the era of the expansion of civil rights that we have studied might be in the process of giving way to a serious backlash and, perhaps, a new era. We’ll have to stay tuned... and vote!

The Cartoons (50 points)

Nay graded all the cartoons and wrote these comments.

Overall, I was impressed with your analyses of the cartoons! If you are confused about your grade, the explanation could be:

- You did not situate your analysis in any time period.
- You misunderstood what the cartoon was depicting and/or the point the cartoonist was making. I got the impression that those of you who may not have paid attention to the lectures struggled with some of the cartoons, all of which were used in Professor Mitchell's lectures.

Common errors for specific cartoons were:

Cartoon 1 "Rwanda"

- No mention of the US (Clinton administration) response to the Rwandan genocide. Some of you never mentioned Rwanda.
- Not understanding that the world, including the Clinton administration, was fully informed that the genocide was occurring.

Cartoon 2 "Next!"

- Failure to place the cartoon in the late 19th/early 20th century, when Roosevelt was fighting trusts. (The only thing not in the creature's grasp is the White House!)

Cartoon 3 "New Member of the Orchestra"

- Missing the context of the Spanish-American War - this is what ushers the United States into the "orchestra" along with the European imperialist powers
- If you missed this context you got a "0" on the cartoon.

Cartoon 4 "Reagan and Gorbachev"

- A few people misunderstood the cartoonist's irony - the cartoon is not praising Reagan; it is saying that Gorbachev is the "real hero" behind the end of the Cold War, but Reagan gets all of the credit. Also, some of you asserted, wrongly, that Gorbachev sought the union of East & West Germany; he did not seek it.
- Some people did not explain the historical context clearly.

Cartoon 5 “What a Lucky Thing We’ve Got Separate Beds!”

- Failure to explain the context of the isolationist movement in the late 1930s/early 1940s.
- The irony of the closeness of the two beds - Seuss is making fun of the isolationists; he is showing that the “contagions” in Europe are right next to us.

Final thoughts

Nay and I have been amazed and impressed by the discipline and seriousness that you have applied to this course. We know it takes extra effort to keep up with an asynchronous zoom class. So we salute you and hope you have a restful, healthy and happy holiday. To those of you who are graduating, hearty congratulations! Please email me if you have any questions about the essays and cartoons.

When I called this “Final” thoughts, I meant it: I am retiring and this is my last class after 30 years at NC State. You have been a great class to end on. Thank you!